Ratan was queried on a host of issues. Joshi questioned him on the reasons why he had moved the Supreme Court. Ratan clarified that his objection was only against the leaking of the tapes as it had led to a trial by media, which had unfairly tarnished the reputation of those involved. He reiterated his argument, stating that ‘it is not for the publications to attribute guilt to people. Why I did this is because my picture is on the cover of magazines saying that I was associated with the 2G scam’. He said that he had recruited Radia in the hope that she ‘would give him a voice in Delhi where the GSM [global system for mobile communication] telecom operators seemed to enjoy an advantage’ as ‘firms like Vodafone and BSNL had got spectrum in excess of their rights’.

Ratan also vehemently denied that he had engaged in any conversation with A. Raja seeking any undue favours. He also refuted charges that he had had any role in Raja’s selection in the Union Cabinet. At the same time, he was upfront in acknowledging that he had faced a ‘chemistry’ problem with the previous Telecom Minister Dayanidhi Maran and had preferred to interact with Raja.

Elaborating on the role played by Radia, Ratan said: ‘She has been our public relations person interacting with the media. She has been no different on advocacy than a CII or a FICCI in terms of endeavouring to have a level playing field. At no stage have we had a facilitator doing more than what I had indicated. We are not her only clients, and she is not captive to us.’ In an emotional appeal, he added, ‘I can speak for what we have done and I can hold my hand to my heart and say that we have not dithered on that at all.’

While Ratan was busy clearing his name and that of the group, his claim of innocence got support from an unexpected source. That the Tata Group had not got favours from any government quarter, but rather got less than others, was corroborated by India’s constitutional authority responsible for scrutinizing the financial dealings of the government, the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) of India.

The CAG in his report of 16 November 2010 concluded that Tata Teleservices was not treated at par with the other operators. He revealed that while there was ‘undue haste’ shown in issuing in-principle approval for the use of GSM technology to some operators, the same ‘was not evident afterwards as when the Tata Teleservices Ltd applied for dual technology immediately after the issue of the Press notification on 19